

ASIA ECONOMICS ANALYST

Chinese Household Balance Sheet: Structural Shift from Property to Financial Assets Amid Ongoing Deleveraging

China in the Long Run

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- China's household balance sheet is becoming increasingly important for the macro outlook. With property a shrinking, although still dominant store of wealth, shifts in household assets and liabilities are now a key driver of confidence, consumption, and capital market performance.
- The PBOC and national think tanks have published household balance sheet estimates in the past, but those data are released with a long lag. To address that gap, we build a quarterly tracker and estimate that aggregate household assets peaked in early 2023, declined for about six quarters in 2023 and 2024, and have broadly stabilized at around RMB730tn in recent quarters.
- On the asset side, the composition of household wealth is shifting. Housing has turned from a driver of asset growth into a drag, while equities and other financial assets have contributed more meaningfully to total asset growth since the September 2024 policy pivot. By our estimates, in mid-2021 when the property market peaked, property, cash/deposits, and other financial assets (including equities and bonds) accounted for 67%, 16% and 15% of household total assets, respectively; in 2026Q1, they accounted for 52%, 25% and 20%, respectively; directly held equities within other financial assets rose from 5% to 6%.
- On the liability side, households remain in a deleveraging phase, with outstanding mortgage balances and short-term consumer loans both declining. While headline household debt-to-GDP ratio looks moderate relative to DM, the debt-to-income ratio remains high, suggesting debt servicing is still burdensome relative to Chinese household cash flow.
- In our view, China's household asset allocation is at the early stage of a structural shift: as property's role in wealth accumulation fades and deposit rates stay low, savings are likely to migrate gradually toward broader financial assets, with equities and insurance the key potential medium-term beneficiaries.

Chinese Household Balance Sheet: Structural Shift from Property to Financial Assets Amid Ongoing Deleveraging

For more than two decades, residential property has served as the main store of wealth for Chinese households, accounting for more than half of total assets. As nominal home prices have fallen by around 30% from their peak, the resulting negative wealth effect has become a persistent drag on household confidence and consumption. Yet investors have lacked a timely framework to assess how quickly Chinese household balance sheets are repairing or deteriorating. While both the PBOC and national think tanks have published household balance sheet estimates, those data are released with a long lag. In this piece, we address that gap by constructing a quarterly household balance sheet tracker. We use it to assess how household assets and liabilities have evolved through the property downturn, quantify the extent of balance-sheet stabilization and deleveraging, and frame the implications for consumption, confidence, and the medium-term outlook for household asset allocation.

The evolution of Chinese household wealth from 1978–2022

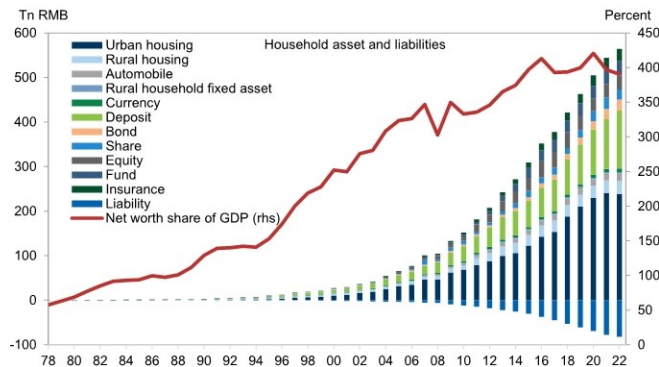
The National Institution for Finance and Development (NIFD), formerly known as the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences (CASS) Financial Laboratory, is a reputable state-run think tank which, through its Center for National Balance Sheet (CNBS), has released annual household balance sheet data covering 1978 to 2022. Their data indicate that the Chinese household balance sheet expanded during this period, with the net worth of households, as a share of GDP, increasing from 200% of nominal GDP in 1997 to around 400% in 2022 ([Exhibit 1](#)).

The annualized growth rate of China's total assets, liabilities, and net worth underwent a three-stage step-down, reflecting slowing growth rates as the size of household balance sheet expanded ([Exhibit 2](#)).

Between 1992 and 2002, a period marked by very low starting levels, household assets grew at an annualized rate of 25%. This rate slowed to 20% during 2002–2012, coinciding with China's entry into the WTO in 2001 and a surge in debt-fueled infrastructure and property investment post the 2008–09 GFC. In the following decade, from 2012 to 2022, growth decelerated further as policymakers increasingly prioritized financial stability and deleveraging, despite several easing cycles including the 2015–18 shantytown redevelopment program.

Throughout these periods, the annualized growth rate of household liabilities consistently exceeded that of household assets, partly owing to the much lower starting point of the former. This led to a structural build-up in leverage across the household sector, primarily fueled by financial market developments and mortgage borrowing during the urbanization and property boom.

Exhibit 1: From 1997 to 2022, the household sector's net worth as a percentage of GDP increased twofold



“Fund” comprises mutual funds, private funds, and wealth management products (WMPs) held by the household sector; “Share” is primarily private portion of net assets of unlisted companies, which are highly concentrated among a limited group of investors or business owners.

Source: CNBS

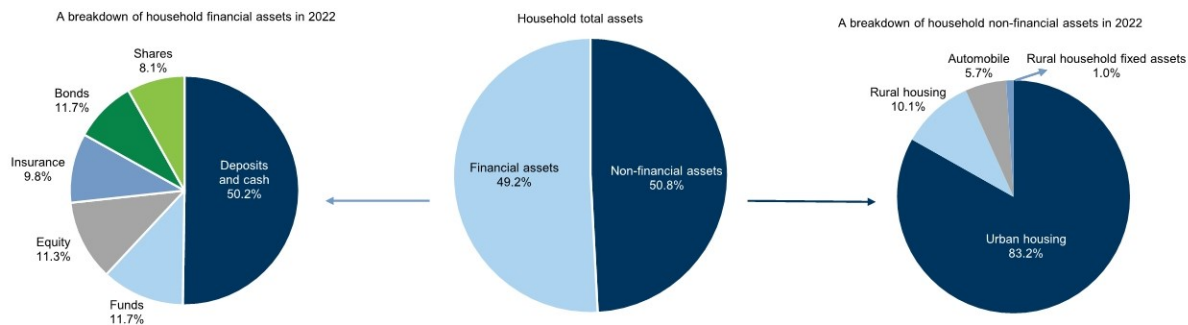
Exhibit 2: Both household asset and liability growth rates moderated over time



Source: CNBS

CNBS data show that, as of 2022, property dominated household non-financial assets, while cash/deposits accounted for around half of financial asset holdings¹ (Exhibit 3). The concentration in a limited set of instruments—primarily residential property and cash/deposits—reflects a shortage of diversified, high-yield investment channels in China.

Exhibit 3: Composition of household assets in 2022



Source: CNBS

¹ The difference in the property share between CNBS and PBOC's 2019 survey estimates, with the latter at roughly 60%, mainly reflects differences in sample coverage: the CNBS data include both urban and rural households, while the PBOC survey covers only urban households.

Box: Constructing quarterly household balance sheet tracker

Although the CNBS data provide valuable insights into the composition of household balance sheets, its lack of timeliness (e.g., 2022 is the most recent data available as of this writing) limits its usefulness for monitoring changes in real time. To address this gap, we have developed a quarterly tracker to assess fluctuations in China's household balance sheet. The tracker covers four main components: financial assets, property values, automobile values, and liabilities.

- For financial assets, we aggregate PBOC data on household bank deposits and currency and assume that the household sector's share in total currency in circulation (among all sectors in the economy) is fixed; historically, this share has been relatively stable at around 82–83%. We then add National Financial Regulatory Administration (NFRA) data on insurance² and Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security of the People's Republic of China (MOHRSS) data on enterprise annuity, China Central Depository & Clearing Co., Ltd. (CCDC) data on bonds and wealth management products, Asset Management Association of China (AMAC) data on mutual funds and private equity held by households, and our equity strategy team's estimate of retail investors' total stock holdings. Admittedly, the tracker does not capture household financial investments held through less transparent channels (e.g., unlisted equity holdings), so our estimate is lower than the annual CNBS level in absolute terms. However, it tracks changes in financial assets relatively closely compared to CNBS data.
- For property, following the methodology detailed in our [previous piece](#), we first estimate the outstanding stock of modern urban housing by cumulating floor area sold to derive the current stock of developer-built urban housing. We then estimate the total value of modern housing by applying our [constructed](#) secondary-market property price series to the housing stock. For non-modern urban housing (defined as housing units not constructed by real estate developers after the 1998 housing reform), we assume property prices are half of those of modern housing, reflecting lower quality and transfer restrictions. For rural housing, we infer value using the rural-to-urban housing value ratio implied by CNBS data. Our property value estimate is significantly higher than the CNBS estimate, mainly reflecting methodological differences: CNBS estimates the urban housing stock by multiplying per-capita living space by the urban population, applies a higher depreciation rate than ours for modern housing, and uses new home prices rather than existing home prices.
- For automobiles, we use cumulative car sales data published by the China Association of Automobile Manufacturers (CAAM) and average passenger car transaction prices disclosed by the China Automobile Dealers Association. We estimate the total value of auto assets using a 10% straight-line depreciation method.
- For liabilities, we use PBOC data on household loans, including consumption loans (mostly mortgages) and operating loans. We also incorporate housing provident fund loans by assuming their share of total household loans based on annual data published by the Ministry of Housing and Urban-Rural Development (MOHURD). According to the [PBOC's 2019 survey](#), bank loans accounted for 97% of total household liabilities.

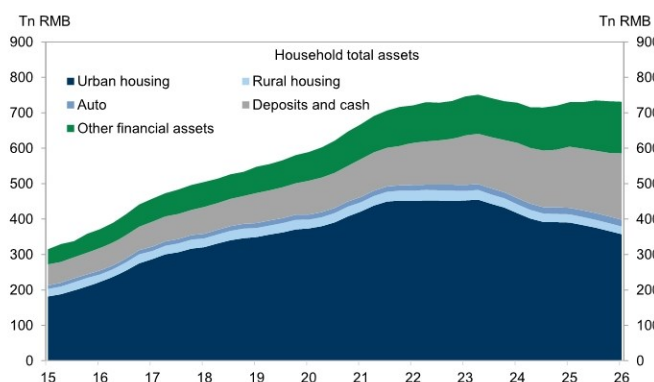
² We use insurers' total assets, including life and property insurance companies, as a proxy for household insurance assets, as their changes have broadly tracked semi-annual household insurance reserves in the NBS flow-of-funds data.

On the asset side, [Exhibit 4](#) suggests that household balance sheets expanded steadily before the property downturn, driven by rising home prices and rapid accumulation in property purchases. This dynamic reversed as the property correction deepened over the past few years, with total household assets declining through late 2024 as falling housing valuations more than offset gains in financial assets. Since then, the balance sheet has stabilized and edged modestly higher, led primarily by stronger financial asset performance following the September 2024 policy pivot, alongside continued accumulation in cash/deposits ([Exhibit 5](#)). As a result, household total assets have plateaued at around RMB730tn in recent quarters. The key shift is that the engine of household asset growth is now rotating away from housing toward financial assets.

That said, stronger financial asset performance is unlikely to lift household consumption meaningfully on its own. Housing still matters much more for the aggregate wealth effect: property accounts for around 60% of household assets, versus less than 10% for equities, and our previous work [suggests](#) the housing wealth effect is more pronounced than the stock market wealth effect. The distribution of gains also matters. More than 90% of households own property, while only around 25% of Chinese adults participate in the equity market. This means weakness in home prices is likely to have a larger impact on mass consumption, whereas gains in financial assets mainly benefit a narrower, higher-income cohort.

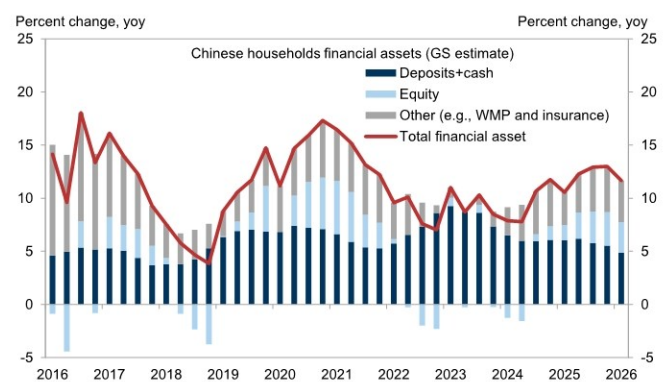
There are, however, early signs that the property drag may be easing. [Our latest high-frequency tracker](#) shows stable sales in both new and existing homes. The [official NBS 70-city indices](#) suggest sequential price declines eased slightly, while prices in Tier-1 cities rose for both new and existing homes. We [continue to expect](#) Tier-1 and Tier-2 cities to achieve local home price stabilization within the next year or two, with Shenzhen and Shanghai likely to lead. If that happens and barring additional negative shocks (e.g., significant AI displacement of workers), the impact on confidence, household spending, and capital markets could be meaningful, given housing's dominant role in household wealth and broader risk sentiment.

Exhibit 4: Household total assets have remained broadly stable in recent quarters



Source: Wind, CEIC, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 5: Since the September 2024 policy pivot, equities have contributed more to financial asset growth

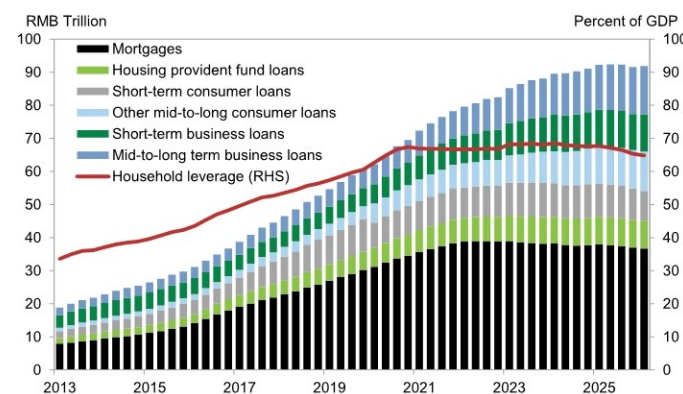


Source: Wind, CEIC, Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Continued household deleveraging

On the liability side, [Exhibit 6](#) shows that household leverage has started to drift lower since mid-2024, driven primarily by a decline in outstanding mortgage balances. This points to a shift in household behavior from credit expansion to balance-sheet repair, as early mortgage repayments and subdued home purchase demand reduce housing-related borrowing. Short-term consumption loans have also softened, underscoring still-cautious household demand beyond housing. Policymakers have responded by lowering mortgage rates and, more recently, rolling out [interest subsidies](#) for household consumer loans to reduce borrowing costs and support household credit demand. So far, however, the impact has been limited amid [a still-weak labor market](#) and fragile household confidence, and the household sector remains in a deleveraging phase.

Exhibit 6: Household leverage has been drifting lower since mid-2024

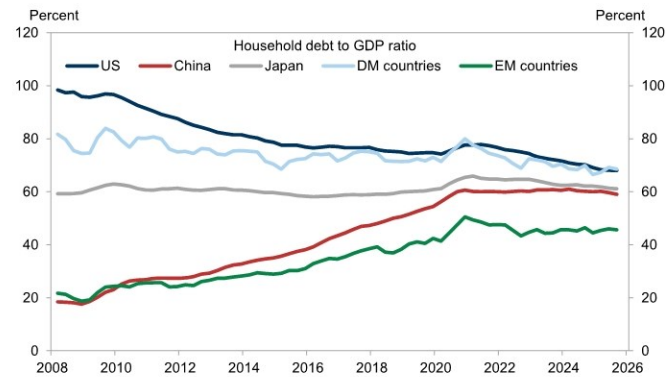


Source: PBOC, MOHURD, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Compared to other countries, China's household leverage does not look especially stretched on a headline debt-to-GDP ratio basis, but appears materially higher when measured against household income.

China's household debt-to-GDP ratio peaked at 61% in early 2024 and has since moderated to approximately 59% in Q3 2025, based on the latest BIS data ([Exhibit 7](#)). Compared with major peers, this is below the United States (~70%) and Japan (~62%), but above the EM average (~45%). Although the Chinese household debt-to-GDP ratio appears in line with other countries, its household debt-to-disposable income ratio stood at around 140% as of 2025, high relative to major countries ([Exhibit 8](#)). The reason is straightforward: household disposable income accounts for only around 45% of GDP in China, versus roughly 75% in the United States. In other words, while debt appears manageable relative to aggregate output, it looks much heavier relative to the income that actually accrues to households.

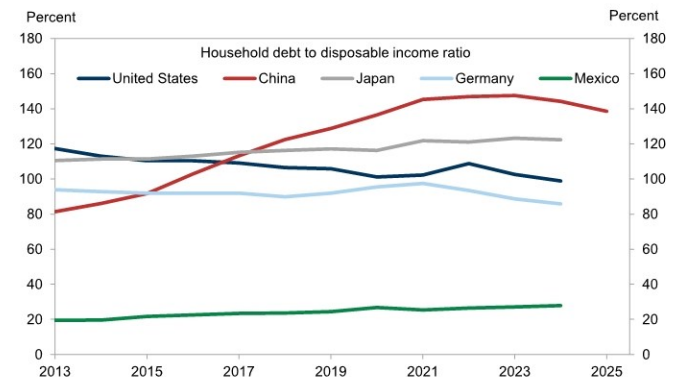
Exhibit 7: China's household debt to GDP ratio was high versus EM countries, but below DM countries



2025Q3 is the latest data available.

Source: BIS

Exhibit 8: China's household debt-to-income ratio is high relative to major economies



The latest available data are for 2025 for China, based on GS estimates, and 2024 for all other countries, based on OECD data

Source: OECD, NBS, MOHURD, PBOC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

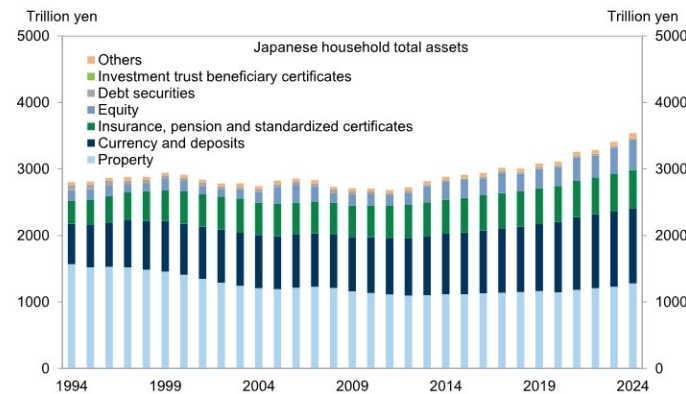
Taken together, the household balance sheet appears to be stabilizing, but the drivers of wealth are shifting. Property remains the dominant determinant of confidence and consumption, but it has moved from being the main engine of asset growth to a drag, while financial assets are starting to contribute more at the margin. This raises the next key question for the macro outlook: how far and how fast will Chinese households reallocate savings away from property toward financial assets?

From Bricks to Beta: A gradual shift in household asset allocation

History suggests that such a rotation is rarely immediate. When property stops delivering capital gains and balance-sheet repair becomes the priority, households typically move only gradually into financial assets, with preferences shaped by confidence, income security, and the relative attractiveness of returns on a volatility-adjusted basis.

The experience of Japan and the United States suggests that a housing bust does not automatically trigger a rapid rotation from real estate to financial assets. In Japan, the collapse of the property and equity bubbles in the 1990s was followed by a prolonged period in which households remained heavily tilted toward cash and deposits, reinforcing a preference for liquidity and safety rather than a decisive shift into equities ([Exhibit 9](#)). The US experience after 2008 was somewhat different: households deleveraged and gradually rebuilt financial wealth, but the recovery in risk-asset participation was uneven and concentrated more heavily among higher-wealth cohorts, while middle-income households continued to hold a large share of their wealth in housing. The broader lesson for China is that a property downturn can create the conditions for portfolio reallocation, but the transition is typically slow, highly skewed toward affluent households.

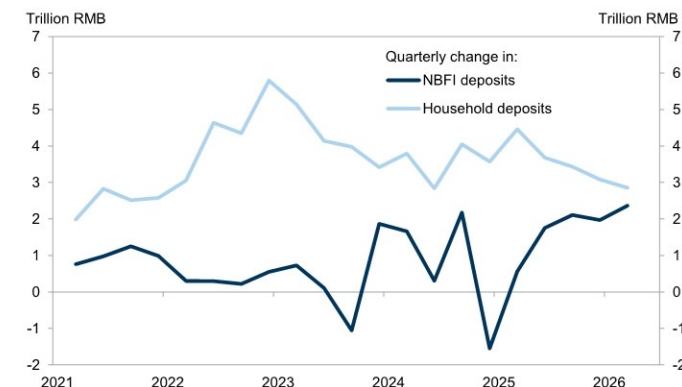
Exhibit 9: Cash and deposits have remained above 30% of household total assets in Japan



Source: BOJ

In China, one catalyst for a gradual portfolio shift could be the steady decline in deposit rates. As policymakers ease financial conditions while protecting banks' net interest margins, the 3-year time deposit rate has fallen to 1.25%, a significant drop from 1.95%/2.60% in the beginning of 2024/2023. The spread between 3-year and 1-year deposits has also narrowed from 50-100bps to 30bps. As a result, households are increasingly being pushed to look beyond deposits for returns. Early signs of this rotation are visible in the rise of deposits held by non-bank financial institutions (NBFIs), which likely reflects funds moving into wealth management products, mutual funds, insurance, and equities ([Exhibit 10](#)). In our view, the shift is still at an early stage, but it points to a gradual reallocation of household savings away from property and low-yielding deposits toward a broader set of financial assets, with potentially important implications for capital markets.

Exhibit 10: An emerging trend of capital shifting from bank deposits into risky assets



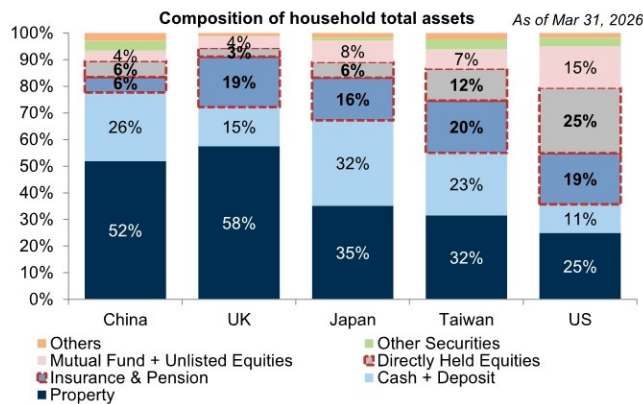
Source: Wind

Against this backdrop, China's household equity allocation still appears low relative to its long-term potential. Equities account for less than 10% of household assets, suggesting meaningful room for further portfolio reallocation as households gradually broaden their investment universe ([Exhibit 11](#)). That said, the adjustment is unlikely to be linear or broad-based, given still-cautious risk appetite and the uneven distribution of financial wealth. Even so, if confidence stabilizes and capital market returns prove attractive,

equities are likely to capture a larger share of incremental household savings over time.

Insurance also represents an area of medium-term growth within China's household portfolio. Insurance products still account for a relatively small share of household assets compared with major developed markets, where life insurance and pension products play a much larger role in long-duration household savings. This gap likely reflects differences in pension system depth, financial market development, and the historical dominance of property and bank deposits in Chinese household wealth ([Exhibit 12](#)). In our view, insurance could gradually capture a larger share of incremental household savings over time, particularly given its dual role as both a savings vehicle and a form of precautionary protection.

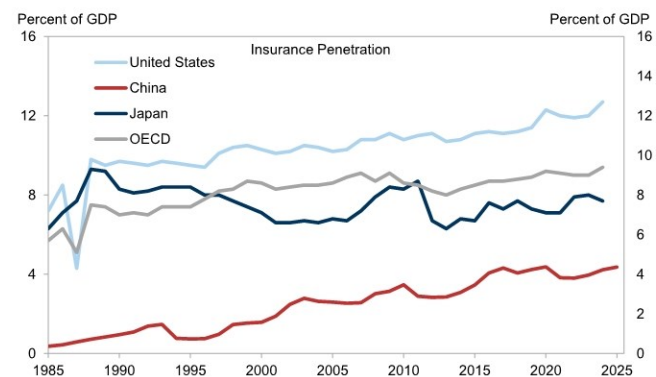
Exhibit 11: China's household equity and insurance allocation still appears low relative to developed markets



Here, "unlisted equities" refer to privately held ownership stakes in companies that are not listed or traded on public exchanges. For China, given limited visibility into household unlisted equity holdings, we use private equity held by the household sector as a proxy.

Source: CEIC, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

Exhibit 12: China's insurance penetration remains low relative to OECD peers



Source: OECD, Wind

Looking ahead, we think China's household balance sheet will continue to shift gradually away from property and toward broader financial assets over the next decade. Our base-case estimates are informed by the post-housing-bust experiences of Japan and the United States, and a gradual rise in China's insurance penetration ratio over time. On that basis, we think property could decline from around 52% of household assets today to roughly 42% by 2035, reflecting weak house price growth and slower new housing demand. By contrast, assuming directly held household equities grow by 10% per year, broadly in line with past experience, their share could rise from around 6% of household assets today to 11% by 2035. This likely understates households' total equity exposure, as more households are using passive investment vehicles, such as mutual funds, to invest in stocks. Insurance could increase from around 6% to roughly 10% of household assets, adding roughly RMB6tn per year from valuation changes and net household inflows after claims and surrenders. We expect deposits to remain broadly stable as a share of household assets, given still-elevated precautionary savings. While the pace of adjustment is unlikely to be linear, the broader implication is that even a gradual rotation in household portfolios could become a meaningful structural source of demand for both equity and insurance markets.

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